

Infusions

An infusion is the simplest way to prepare the more delicate aerial parts of plants, especially leaves and flowers, for use as a medicine or as a revitalizing or relaxing drink. It is made in a similar way to tea, using either a single herb or a combination of herbs, and may be drunk hot or cold.

The medicinal value of many herbs lies chiefly in their volatile oils, which will disperse into the air if a lid is not used. This is especially important in the case of German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77). Use a teapot, or place a lid or saucer over a cup if making a small quantity. Use water that has just boiled. Popular herbal teas, such as German chamomile, are often taken as much for their refreshing taste as for their medicinal value and can be safely consumed in quantities of up to 5 or 6 cups a day. Some herbs, however, such as yarrow (*Achillea millefolium*, p. 56), are significantly stronger and must be taken in less frequent doses. Other herbs, such as feverfew (*Tanacetum parthenium*, p. 140), are so strong that they are not suitable for use in infusions. Always check the recommended dosage and quantity of herb to use, as infusions have medicinal actions and can produce unwanted effects at the wrong dosage.



1 Place the herb in the strainer of the teacup and place a strainer in the cup. Fill the cup with freshly boiled water.

2 Cover the cup with the lid and infuse for 5–10 minutes before removing the tea strainer. Add a teaspoon of honey to sweeten, if desired.

Standard Quantity

CUP 1 tsp (2–3 g) dried or 2 tsp (4–6 g) fresh herb (or mixture of herbs) to a cup of water (this makes 1 dose)

POT 20 g dried herb or 30 g fresh herb (or a mixture of different herbs) to 2 cups (500 ml) of water

Standard Dosage

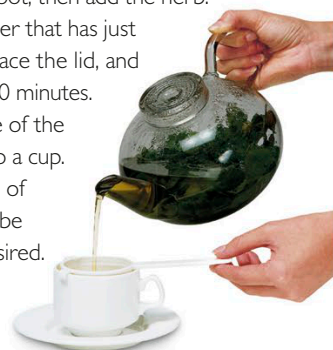
Take 3–4 doses (2 cups/500 ml) each day.

Storage

Store in a covered jug in a refrigerator or cool place for up to 24 hours.

Pot Infusion

Warm the pot, then add the herb. Pour in water that has just boiled, replace the lid, and infuse for 10 minutes. Strain some of the infusion into a cup. A teaspoon of honey may be added if desired.



Decoctions

Roots, bark, twigs, and berries usually require a more forceful treatment than leaves or flowers to extract their medicinal constituents. A decoction involves simmering these tougher parts in boiling water. Fresh or dried plant material may be used and should be cut or broken into small pieces before decocting. Like infusions, decoctions can be taken hot or cold.

Decoctions are generally made using roots, bark, and berries, but sometimes leaves and flowers may be included. Add these more delicate parts of a plant once the heat is turned off and the decoction has finished simmering and is beginning to cool. Then strain and use as required.

Chinese Decoctions

In traditional Chinese medicine, decoctions are the main way in which herbal medicines are prepared. Large quantities of herb are often used to produce a highly concentrated liquid, or the decoction is further reduced so that there is only $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (200 ml) of liquid remaining. This increases the preparation's concentration. This process is useful for astringent barks such as babul (*Acacia nilotica*, p. 159) and common oak (*Quercus robur*, p. 260), which may be used externally to tighten gums or wash weeping skin rashes. (Do not take internally.)



1 Place the herbs in a saucepan. Cover with cold water and bring to a boil. Simmer for about 20–30 minutes, until the liquid is reduced by about one-third.

2 Strain the liquid through a sieve into a jug. Pour the required amount into a cup, then cover the jug and store in a cool place.

Standard Quantity

20 g dried or 40 g fresh herb (or mixture of herbs) to 3 cups (750 ml) cold water, reduced to about 2 cups (500 ml) after simmering (this makes 3–4 doses)

Standard Dosage

Take 3–4 doses (2 cups/500 ml) each day.

Storage

Store in a covered jug in a refrigerator or cool place for up to 48 hours.

